it myself; and for that purpose knocked hard at the outer gate, and immediately went forward through the guard to the drawbridge before the entrance of the castle. But while I was contemplating this gloomy mansion, an officer came out much surprised; and I was forced to retreat through the mute guard, and thus regained that freedom, which for one locked up within those walls it is next to impossible to obtain.

Many of my readers, acquainted with the strict policy of France, would have supposed that the other prisons would have been as inaccessible to a visitant as the Bastille. And indeed my first application for admittance at the Grand Châtelet was unsuccessful. But fortunately remarking the tenth article[1] of the *arrêt* 1717, I pleaded it before the Commissaire de la Prison, to whom I was referred, and by its means gained admission as well into that prison, as those of Le Petit Châtelet and For-l'Evêque, and had an opportunity of seeing almost every individual confined in them.

In the provincial gaols I saw little worth noting, but what has been already mentioned at Paris. These also have charitable patronesses, who take care that the prisoners be not defrauded of their allowance; and procure them further relief. But these prisons do not seem to be so carefully inspected as those in the city; although the *arrêts* of Parliament for regulation of both are for the most part similar, and were made in the same year, 1717. They are drawn up with sound judgment, and accurate knowledge of the complex subject. I found many articles of them in the laws of other nations; but cannot say whether the French *arrêts* were compiled from them, or followed by them.

The 32nd article of the *arrêt* for the provinces requires that prisons be *au raiz de chausseé*, level with the ground. Yet at Chalons, and some other towns, I saw many prisoners in dungeons; larger indeed, but in other respects not much better

power of any, the highest, magistrate to imprison arbitrarily whomever he or his officers thought proper, (as in France it is daily practised by the crown [2]) there would soon be an end of all other rights and immunities."

[1] The article is as follows: "Les geôliers conduiront les personnes qui viendront faire des charités dans les lieux de la prison où elles désireront les distribuer, ce qu'elles pourront faire elles-mêmes sur le préau ou dans la cour; mais les aumônes ne pourront être distribuées dans les cachots noirs que par les mains du geôlier, en présence des personnes qui les porteront."

[2] "I have been assured upon good authority, that, during the mild administration of Cardinal Fleury, above 54,000 *lettres de cachet* were issued, upon the single ground of the famous *bulle Unigenitus*."—*Commentaries*, Book I, chap. 1.

than those at Paris. In the four horrid ones at the Prison de St. Joseph (formerly a convent) at Lyons, June 1776, were twenty-nine criminals: the heat so excessive, that few of them had any other garment on than their shirts. Some of them were sick: none looked healthy. In the nine other rooms of that gaol there were one hundred and twenty-eight prisoners; of which number twenty-two were women.

To the Pierre-en-cize, a State prison at Lyons, you ascend by more than two hundred steps: among the few prisoners in it, I sat talking awhile with one who said he was in the fiftieth year of his confinement.

DUNKIRK. In the prison at Dunkirk, the French prisoners were in two or three rooms by themselves.

Here (January 1779) I found many of my countrymen prisoners of war. In five rooms there were a hundred and thirty-three—captains, mates, passengers, and common sailors all crowded together—who lay on straw, with one coverlet for every three persons. In three other rooms there were thirteen accommodated in a better manner, because most of them were ransomers, and capable of paying six sous a night for their beds.[1] The court was small, being only forty-two feet by twenty-six; nor was there sufficient plenty of water. The bread, beer, and soup were good, and the beef tolerable. In a former war, the contract here was twelve sous a man; in the last it was fifteen. Each room was supplied with two small faggots a day for firing. The sick (of whom there were only three) were taken to the military hospital. The regulations were hung up in English and French.

BERGUES. In the prison at Bergues I found forty-seven English prisoners. The table of victualling was hung up here as at Dunkirk, but the provisions were not so good. There were twelve on their parole in this town, nine at Bourbourg, and two at Ardres, who told me they had procured bondsmen for their security.

CALAIS. The common prison at Calais, being smaller than that at Dunkirk, was much crowded: for it contained one hundred and twenty-seven English prisoners. Seventeen sailors lay in one room [2] on straw, without coverlets; a few had not even

[1] A ransomer is a person confined as a security, till the sum is paid for which a ship has been ransomed.

[2] That room was nineteen feet by twelve. In another smaller room, in two tiers, were twenty-three hammocks belonging to the sailors; for sometimes their hammocks were given them. The court of this prison was only twenty-five feet by fourteen and a half.